



CaveChat, 2005–2026

The life of the NSS discussion forum, told from public records only

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How this account was built, and what it leaves out

Board records

Minutes, agendas and officer reports, 2002–2026, from caves.org. 112 documents mention the forum.

The capture index

The Internet Archive's public index of 782,179 captures: dates, addresses and status codes. No page content.

Twenty front pages

Archived copies of the forum's public front page, about one a year, for section names and the running totals phpBB shows every visitor.

The registry

The .org registry's public record for cavechat.org: dates, registrar, nameservers.

Deliberately not read: any archived topic, profile, member list or search page. Those carry members' names, comments and opinions. Usernames printed on the front page were blanked before writing. Every request was read-only, identified, rate-limited and logged.

Five things the record establishes

1

Alive 2005–2025

The forum ran from 1 Sept 2005 until it went dark on or about 28 March 2025: nineteen and a half years.

2

Never at cavechat.org

The name was only ever a forwarding address. The forum lived on NSS servers: caves.org/phpBB2, then forums.caves.org.

3

Fast rise, long fade

~16,000 posts a year to 2011; under 1,000 by 2017; dozens a year after 2021. Registrations never stopped: 8,732 accounts at the end.

4

Retired on paper in 2021

The Board rescinded its Act in March 2021 and promised an archive for members. The forum ran four more years; no archive was reported.

5

The domain moved in Sept 2026

cavechat.org was transferred to a new registrar on 28 Sept 2026 and pointed at AWS. Who holds it is not public.



Origins

A discussion board before there was a CaveChat, 2002–2005

The NSS already had a discussion board

By 2002 the NSS website's navigation carried a "Discussion Board" link, at caves.org/soapbox. The Board used it: motions and agendas were posted there as they developed, and directors were encouraged to take part.

"Announcements are posted for NSS members, questions posed for Board members and cavers, information exchanged on expeditions, caving and rescue techniques, conservation, photography, and education, and lively discussions are guaranteed. There's even gear swap and humor sections."

NSS News, January 2005, President's column



Sources: *business_documents* 2002-12-20; *finance.html* 2004-06-20; *0411BOG.pdf* p.8; *jan05.pdf*; 2005 *survey.pdf* p.77

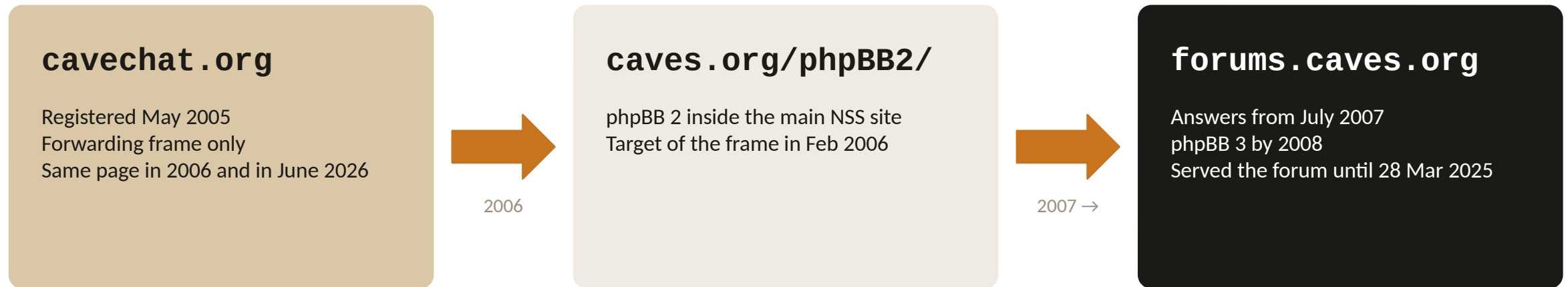
2005: name first, forum second, Board motion third



Sources: data/cavechat_rdap.json; 0507BOG.pdf p.3; 0511BOG.pdf p.3; raw/cavechat/20070921; Wayback capture 2006-02-09

Where the forum actually lived

cavechat.org never hosted anything. Every archived copy of it, 2006 to 2026, is a one-frame page from a domain-forwarding service that loads the real forum from an NSS address. CaveChat was the brand; the forum ran on NSS infrastructure for its whole life.



What the forum told crawlers: for most of 2007–2021 forums.caves.org had no robots.txt at all. Briefly “Disallow: /” in February 2007; otherwise the standard phpBB list that keeps crawlers out of posting, search, login, profiles, the member list and private messages. The “automated access refused” seen at cavechat.org today comes from whatever has served the name since 2025, not from the forum.

Sources: raw/cavechat/robots/ (30 archived versions); raw/cavechat/2006–2026 front pages

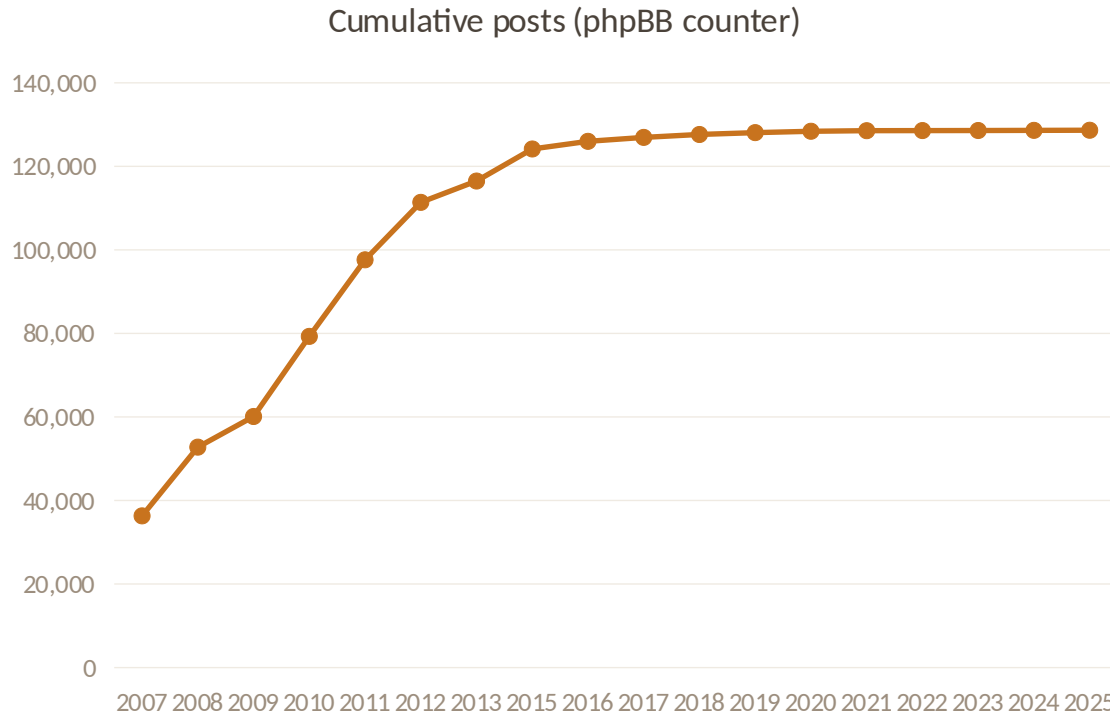
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Growth and decline

What the forum's own front page counted, 2007–2025

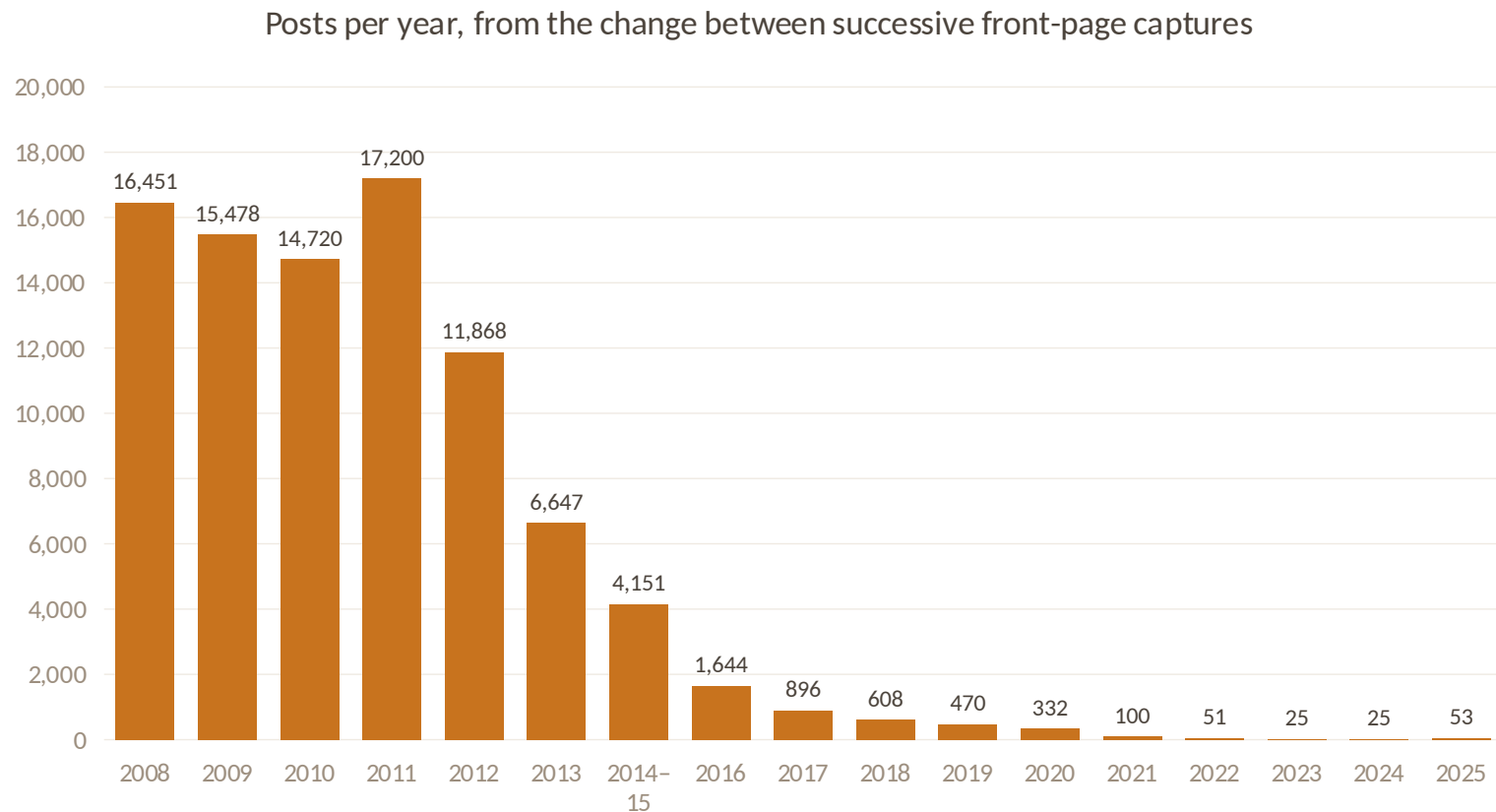
Posts stopped growing in 2014; accounts never did



Posts: 36,312 in Sept 2007 → 116,479 in mid-2013 → 128,639 in Jan 2025. Two-thirds of everything ever posted was posted by 2013. Accounts: 1,740 → 8,732. The 2019–2025 account growth, a few hundred a year on a forum nobody was moderating, is almost certainly automated registration; the Board's own 2013 reports already mention spam countermeasures.

Source: [data/cavechat_timeseries.csv](#) (front-page totals; the Board's reported figures for 2008–2013 agree within a few percent)

Posting rate: a cliff in 2013, a long tail after 2016



16,000

posts a year, 2007-2011

896

posts in the year to July 2017

24

posts in the whole of 2024

Source: [data/cavechat_timeseries.csv](#). Each bar is the difference between two captures divided by the days between them, scaled to a year.

What the Society used it for, in its own reports

Information channel

“From event notices and NSS announcements to information on White Nose Syndrome and new products for caving.” The WNS Liaison distributed research updates through it; the ACA solicited incident reports; committee chairs posted their reports there.

Organizational space

Grottos asked for and got sub-forums (“several” by 2009). A “private and secure forum space” for committee work replaced Yahoo groups. Companion sites under the same sub-committee: OnlineCavers.com and the NSS Flickr group.

A place things flared up

A book advertised on the NSS News back cover: the author “spent some time putting out that fire on the Cavechat forum.” 2015: a thread about grotto newsletters on KIP and possible cave-location disclosure led KIP to pull every grotto newsletter.

Run by volunteers

Terms of Service (2009); a moderators’ SOP on personal-data requests; a 15-post minimum before selling; phpBB upgrades and a fresh reinstall (2011); a server crash restored from the administrator’s own backups (2012); weekly digests on Caving News (2012–13).

2014–2020: the reports go quiet, the admin post goes vacant

2013	Last Board report with forum statistics (6,177 members, 116,484 posts).	Aug 2017	Outage: the forum's web server was reaching its database by public address; fixed after a firewall change exposed it.
2014	CaveChat appears only as one channel among several: "FB, Twitter, Cave Chat, and TAG-Net."	Oct 2017	Social Media Committee still deciding "which NSS team will moderate content CaveChat."
2015–17	IT Division lists "CaveChat online forum", with its administrator, among its activities.	2018–19	A new administrator is listed.
Jun 2017	OVP: "looking for a webmaster and someone to take on CaveChat." Directory: admin vacant.	2020–24	"Vacant, Cave Chat admin@cavechat.org" in every OVP directory through March 2024.

Sources: OVP-1308 p.9; AVP-1403 p.17; OVP-1507/1510/1603/1703; OVP-1706 p.2; OVP-1710 p.8; PRES-1710 p.13; OVP-1803–2403 directories



Retired on paper

March 2021, and the four years that followed

March 2021: the Act is rescinded, an archive promised

“Cavechat.org has been unmaintained and unmanaged for some time. Utilization of the platform is low, with some forums not receiving more than one or two posts per year. While Cavechat still functions we will archive and preserve the contents of the site for future members while looking to more appropriate community-based discussion solutions for the 2020s. The NSS Discussion forum hosted at cavechat.org shall be archived by the IT Division and retired. The archive shall be made available to NSS members.”

Agenda, March 2021 meeting, item 10

The vote

“Rescind Act 66-764, NSS Discussion Forum. Urbanski moved ... Passed in Consent Agenda. PASSED.” No discussion is recorded.

The verdict, same meeting

President’s report: the NSS Community Facebook group “has essentially fulfilled the role that CaveChat previously did.”

Two months earlier, on 3–4 January 2021, the Internet Archive recorded 334,000 captures of the forum in two days: 304,000 topic pages, 24,000 posting pages, 6,500 member-list pages, 1,000 attachments. A deliberate, complete crawl. Who initiated it is not recorded. It is the only complete archive of the forum in public view.

Sources: Agenda-2103.pdf p.4; 2103BOG.pdf p.3 item 10; PRES-2103.pdf p.18; data/cavechat_cdx.jsonl (2021-01-03/04)

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2021–2025: retired in the Manual, running on the server

On paper

- Act 66-764 rescinded, March 2021.
- BOG Manual, June 2022 and Oct 2023: still prints the NSS Forum Sub-Committee policy, “currently phpBB”, backups, promotion.
- OVP directory to March 2024: “Vacant, Cave Chat admin@cavechat.org”.
- Code of Conduct: Cavechat.org named as an NSS internal community.
- 2026 Youth Group Coordinator guidelines: link to “the Youth Groups section on the NSS discussion board”.

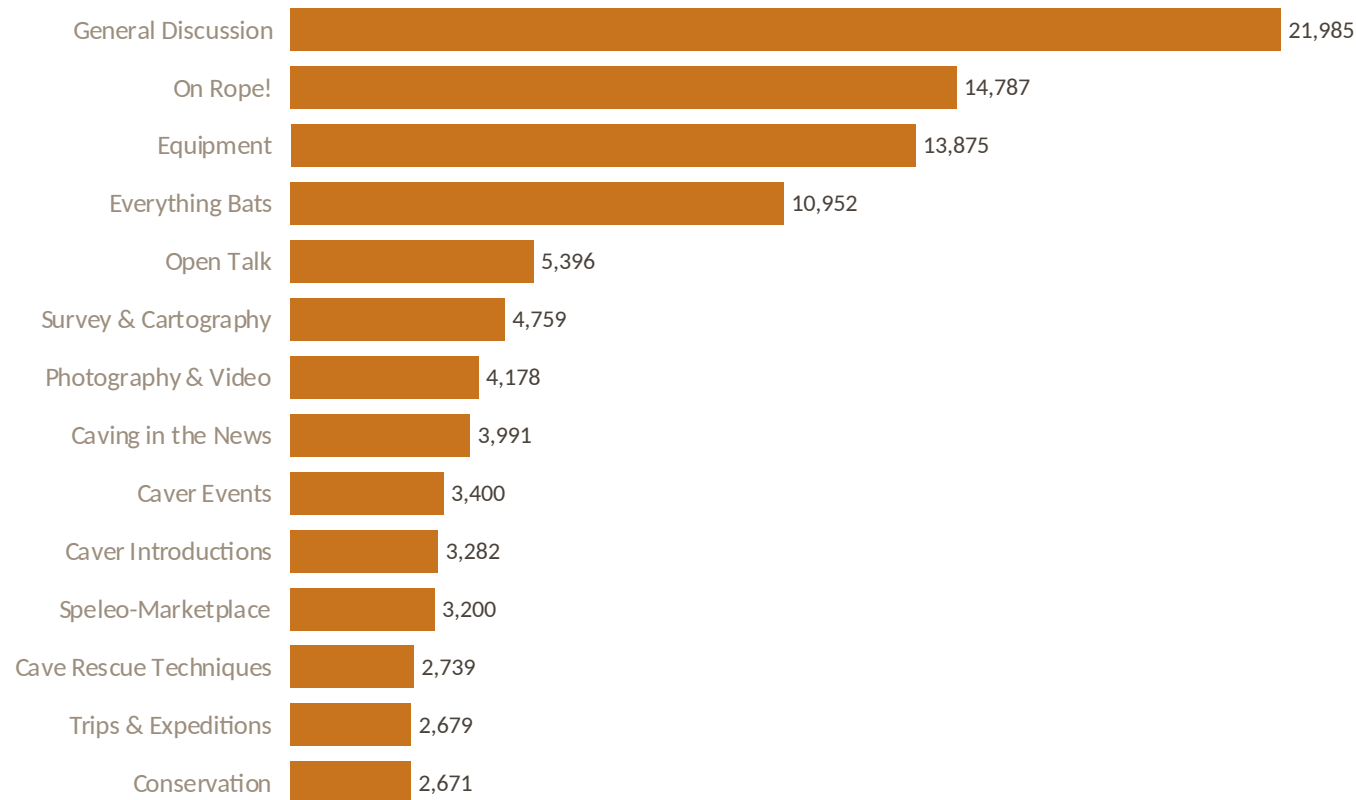
In fact

- Front page served normally, HTTP 200, every month to 28 March 2025.
- Posts: 128,533 (Nov 2021) → 128,639 (Jan 2025). 106 posts in 38 months.
- Last human posts: 6 Nov, 28 Nov and 2 Dec 2024.
- Nov 2021 front page shows an announcements thread, “The forum is back up again!”: an outage around the vote.
- The Internet Archive crawled it at ~14,000 captures a month through 2024.

Sources: *Board_of_Governors_Manual.pdf* 2022 p.532, 2023 p.550; *2403-OVP.pdf* p.1; *Youth-Group-Cordinator-Guidelines.pdf*; *raw/cavechat/2021–2025 front pages*; *data/cavechat_cdx.jsonl*

Where the activity was: the 27 sections at the last capture

Posts by section, 25 January 2025 (top 14 of 27)



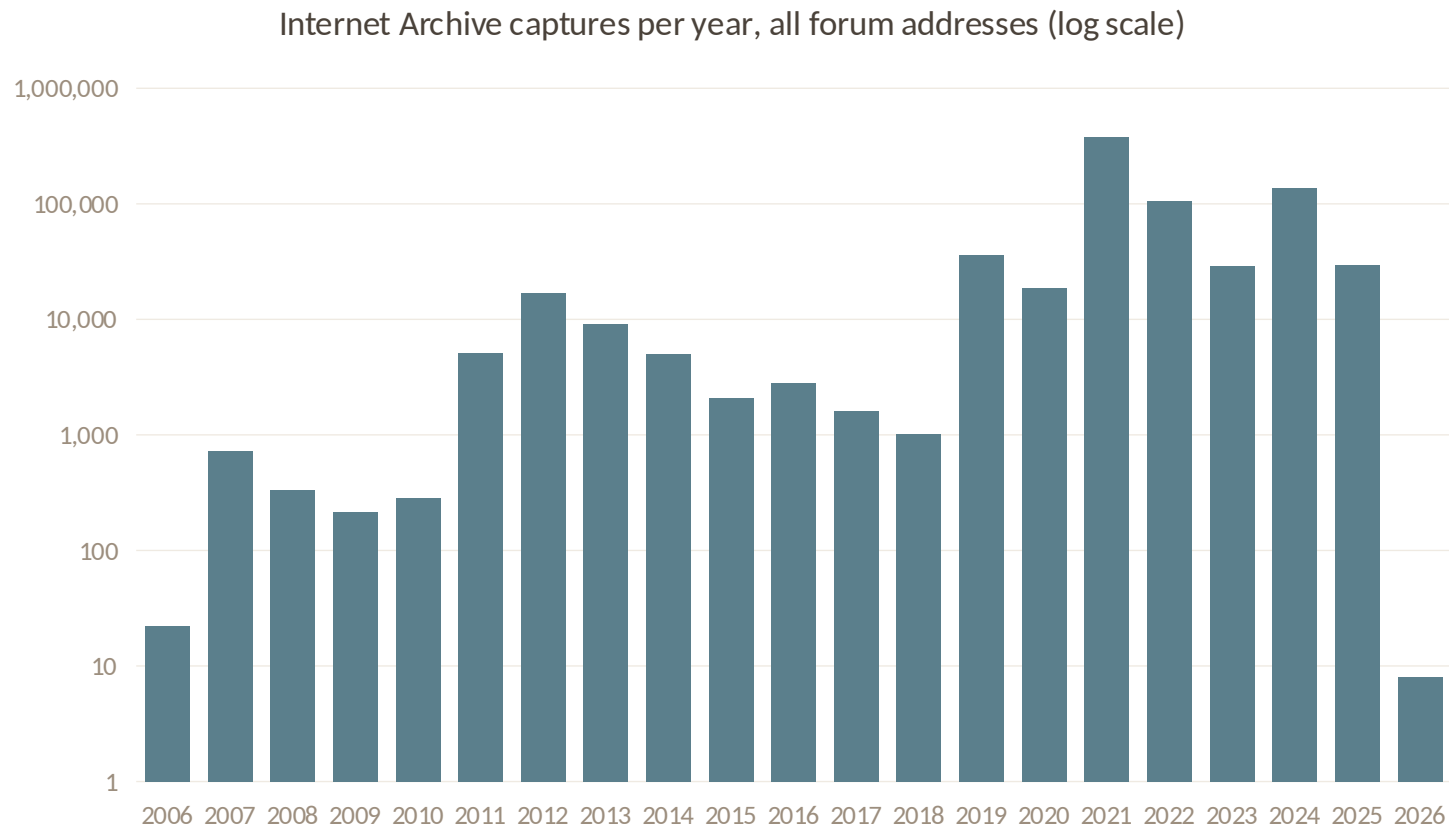
Last post, by section

Dec 2024	Communications & Electronics
Nov 2024	General Discussion; Photography; Publications
Jun 2024	On Rope!; Everything Bats; Survey & Cartography
Mar 2021	Conservation
Jan 2019	Open Talk
Aug 2015	NSS Announcements
Jan 2011	NSS Archives

Three sections, General Discussion, On Rope! and Equipment, hold 39% of all posts. The forum had been reorganized since 2008, when Grotto Forums (4,006 posts) and NSS Topics (2,283) were major sections; neither survives in that form.

Source: [data/cavechat_sections.csv](#) (from the archived front page of 2025-01-25; 2008 figures from 2008-09-20)

28 March 2025: the last capture of a working forum



16:53 UTC

28 March 2025: last capture of forums.caves.org that returned a forum page

After that: not one capture of forums.caves.org. Only one or two a month of cavechat.org, each a 352-byte forwarding frame still pointing at the dead host, last seen 10 June 2026.

No public NSS document found so far records the shutdown or its cause. The 2025 and 2026 Board packets in the archive are silent on it.

Source: data/cavechat_cdx.jsonl. The 2021 spike is the two-day crawl of 3–4 January; the 2019 and 2024 peaks are routine Archive crawling.

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The domain: untouched for twenty years, moved in 2026

3 May 2005	Registered
Feb 2006	Forwarding frame → caves.org/phpBB2
2007–2025	Forwarding frame → forums.caves.org
Aug 2022	An announcements thread asks who holds the Google Workspace for @cavechat.org email
10 Jun 2026	Frame still points at the dead host
28 Sep 2026	Transferred to Amazon Registrar, Inc.
3 Oct 2026	Record last changed; nameservers now AWS Route 53
3 May 2028	Expires

What the registry shows

Registrar: Amazon Registrar, Inc.
Status: client transfer prohibited
Nameservers: four awsdns hosts (Route 53)
DNSSEC: not signed
Registrant, admin and technical contacts: withheld. The only published contact is Amazon's abuse desk.

What it does not show

Whether the NSS made the transfer (consolidating domains at AWS would be unremarkable) or someone else did. The transfer's date is noted; the public record does not say who made it or why. The Society's own records are the only place this can be settled.

Sources: [data/cavechat_rdap.json](#) (rdap.publicinterestregistry.org, 2026-10-09); [raw/cavechat/2026 front pages](#); [raw/cavechat/20250125 front page](#)

Five things only the Society can answer

Why did it go dark?

Nothing public records a decision, a migration or a failure in March 2025.

Where is the members' archive?

Promised in the March 2021 motion; never reported delivered.

Who holds cavechat.org now?

Transferred 28 Sept 2026; registrant withheld. Does the NSS still control the name?

Who made the Jan 2021 crawl?

334,000 captures in two days, two months before the vote.

Does the database survive?

Twenty years of the Society's public conversation: on NSS equipment, or gone?

These read as a ready-made set of questions for the IT Division or the Board. Each is answerable from records the Society holds and none requires reading a single member's post.

Method, limits and where to check

What was requested

A few index queries to the Internet Archive's public CDX API; 30 archived robots.txt files; 24 archived front pages; one registry (RDAP) lookup. Nothing from the live cavechat.org or forums.caves.org servers.

How

The same read-only client as the Board-minutes archive: GET/HEAD only, identified by name and contact, 1 request per 2 s to the Archive, robots.txt honored, no cookies, every request logged (data/crawl_log.jsonl).

What was not done

No topic, profile, member-list or search page was read. The “newest member” field phpBB prints was blanked before writing. No username appears in the account or this deck.

Known limits

phpBB counters include deleted posts and hidden sections, so they run a little above the Board's figures. The 2008 OVP report's “5,500 posts” is inconsistent with the front page (52,763) and is treated as a slip. Registrant data is redacted by design.



Nineteen years, 128,639 posts, 8,732 accounts

A public record of the Society's conversation, 2005–2025, whose fate is now a question for the Society itself.